broad-based government and the need to address quickly the twin problems of narcotics and terrorism.

The cable further observed that US government would be interested in knowing the location of ex-Saudi financier and radical Islamist Osama bin Laden.

We had heard previously that he was in the eastern provinces. His continued presence here would not, we believe, serve Afghanistan's interests.

Indian agents with deep penetration in various provinces of Afghanistan had better and more polished intelligence on the Al-Qaeda network and the Taliban than the Americans. When the Americans descended on Afghanistan after 11 September 2001 to pick up information on the unholy nexus between the ISI, Taliban and Al-

Qaeda, they had to rely on local paid informers and ISI officers who hated the presence of American spies in Afghanistan.

Great Betrayal

Intelligence officers in Delhi and abroad confirmed to me that aside from accessing intelligence reports, the CIA's other important task was to gather a list of R&AW officers posted abroad. Rabinder Singh's great betrayal, which was discovered in 2003, revealed the extent of the network of moles the CIA had managed to set up in countries of interest to them.

Intelligence sources told me: After Rabinder Singh's escape from India to the US, the investigation revealed that he indeed gave a list of R&AW officers posted abroad to his handler, Annie. He had compromised the cover of our officers and no one was even